

Personal Statement

Jamie (Yi-Chieh) Cheng

I grew up in Taiwan and came to the United States for college, where I was, in many of my classrooms, the international student still learning how a new educational system worked. I could attend at all because of a four-year full-tuition scholarship—a stranger's decision that my education was worth investing in. Those two experiences, being the one who didn't yet know the unwritten rules and being the one someone chose to support, sit at the center of how I think about advising. I know what it feels like to need someone to slow down, explain the thing everyone else seems to already understand, and assume the best about you. That is the kind of advisor I want to be.

That path also shaped my values and my training. I studied Psychology and Education Studies at Wesleyan, including a Practicum in Education Studies, and went on to a master's in Applied Organizational Psychology—both grounded in the belief that people thrive when systems are designed around how they actually learn and grow. Professionally, I've worked across the U.S., Taiwan, and Denmark, including in an office of 120 people spanning 22 nationalities, where I helped pilot an Inclusive Leadership workshop that scaled to 23 locations. Working across cultures isn't an add-on for me; it's been the everyday texture of my career, and it has made me a careful listener who doesn't assume one approach fits everyone.

I would contribute to inclusive advising practices in concrete ways. First, by practicing proactive, low-barrier outreach—reaching out before a student is in trouble, and making it easy to ask for help, since the students who most need support are often the least likely to seek it. Second, by paying attention to the specific needs of online and non-traditional learners, drawing on my experience designing engagement for remote participants, so that an Ecampus student feels as connected as one on campus. Third, by bringing a habit I rely on in all my work: asking questions before assuming, and building in feedback so I keep learning what different students actually need. I'd be honored to bring this orientation toward equity and belonging to the advising team and to OSU's students.